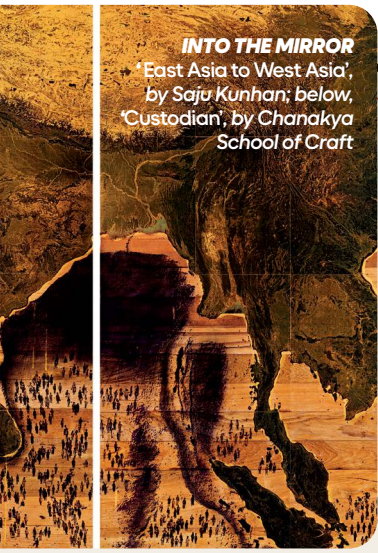


INTO THE MIRROR 'East Asia to West Asia', by Saju Kunhan; below, 'Custodian', by Chanakya School of Craft



Venues across Chennai are abuzz with *Contemporary Now—Edition III*, a citywide showcase of art built around the curatorial theme 'Practices in continuum: tracing the present', featuring 66 artists across 10-plus venues and more than 15 events over 20 days, with the main exhibition at the Lalit Kala Akademi.

For the team, the contemporary is not a break from the past; it is an active conversation with it. The show looks at how artists carry ideas, materials, anxieties, memories and ways of seeing over time. "The exhibition is a continued study of gallery programmes, allowing Chennai audiences to follow artists and galleries across editions," says Priyanjoli Basu, director, *Contemporary Now*.

Throughlines like **URBAN CHANGE, MYTHS, THE BODY AS A SITE OF MEMORY,** have emerged, united by a pan-geographical urgency

Several threads have emerged strongly—the body as a site of memory and identity, material as a way of thinking, ecological and urban change, borders and displacement, personal and collective archives, and the use of myth, ritual and regional histories. Featured artists include Jitish Kallat, Atul Dodiya, Shibu Natesan, Paresh Maity, Jayasri Burman, Madhvi Parekh and many more. "What connects these artists is not style, but urgency. They come from different geographies, experiences and artistic ecosystems, and together they offer a national conversation rather than a single metropolitan viewpoint," says Basu.

Memory is central to this edition. Many works draw from lived experience, family histories, oral traditions, place, community, faith and personal vulnerability. "Archives appear not only as documents but also as emotional structures, things remembered, lost, inherited, reconstructed or questioned. In that sense, the present is not isolated; it is shaped by what we carry with us," says Basu. ■

—Bindu Gopal Rao

The show is on till Aug. 25, with the main exhibition at Lalit Kala Akademi

ART ▼

It's (Not) **Only Words**

KOLKATA'S NATIONAL LIBRARY IS NOW HOME TO THE MUSEUM OF WORD, SHOWCASING INDIA'S MULTILINGUAL HERITAGE





bols in the Indus Valley civilisation to the newest writing system, the Gondi Gunjali script. The artful installation in the lobby depicting an inverted pyramid, a word pole featuring the languages in the Eighth Schedule of the Constitution against the backdrop of a *shunya* is a nice way to showcase our country's contribution to the alphanumeric global stage.

From there on, it moves to myths about India's languages and how they came into being, an installation playing lullabies in each language, a sensory wall depicting all the senses that we identify before we know words for them. Holographic projections of classical dance forms explore each *rasa* and are highlighted with replicas and originals of texts like the *Natyashastra*, *Mridang Manjari* and more.

THE SHOW EXPLORES INDIA'S LINGUISTIC **HERITAGE FROM THE FIRST OBSERVED SYMBOLS IN THE INDUS CIVILISATION** TO THE NEW GONDI GUNJALI SCRIPT

This area in Gallery 3 is a favourite for Partha Sarathi Das, library & information officer, National Library. "I loved that the holographic projections are so well done that it almost looks like a real stage performance," he says. Gallery 4 presents a timeline of languages over 39 bays.

Das's other favourite installation is the final gallery, Gallery 9, which shows a projection on a globe showcasing India's contribution to the global cultural stage through its various land and sea routes. If all the world's a stage, it is here that one realises that India does play a sizeable part. ■

—Malini Banerjee

The exhibition is open 10 am-6 pm, Tues-Sun; closed on public holidays